



Sourcing Products and Supplies

Consider how and where to find the supplies you need to produce your product. Look for stock that is both safe and ethically produced, and weigh up whether to source it locally or internationally.

Choosing suppliers

There are various factors to consider when deciding on a supplier, including price, safety, quality, and durability of your product, along with the (proven) reliability of your supplier. Ask who else they supply and if they have industry-standard documentation.

It is cheaper to buy direct from a manufacturer or factory, but it might not be possible to buy your supplies in small enough quantities, and you may be asked to put down a deposit on initial orders.

A distributor (a firm that distributes goods on behalf of manufacturers) will probably sell smaller amounts, though most likely at a higher price. Small producers offer a personal service, but they may not be able to guarantee continuity of supply, fast turnaround, or all relevant ethical and safety standards.

Research suppliers by visiting trade shows and networking with people in your industry via LinkedIn or similar websites. Visit possible suppliers to see how they operate and ensure they grasp the

needs of your business. If buying from abroad, be aware of language barriers: communicate simply or consider using a translator.

Make, reuse, or buy?

In some cases, it might be better to make the product yourself rather than buy it in. But always consider if this time would be better spent enhancing or running other aspects of the business. Sourcing recycled, reused, or repurposed items and materials could be a cheap and ethical option.



Reused or repurposed

Reused or vintage items have environmental benefits and may be cheaper, but maintaining consistent quality, quantity, and safety may be a problem.



Small, local suppliers

Buying from producers nearby supports the local community and reduces delivery miles. However, local producers often carry a limited range of goods and can be more expensive.

